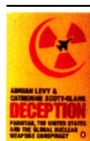


THE ORIGINAL NUCLEAR ROGUES

How Pakistan peddled nuclear secrets in the black market with no interference from the knowing US



DECEPTION: PAKISTAN, THE UNITED STATES, AND THE SECRET TRADE IN NUCLEAR WEAPONS
by ADRIAN LEVY, CATHERINE SCOTT-CLARK
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■ By Manvendra Singh

It was an outright lie. The President lied." In a book on Pakistan's proliferation, a line like this would obviously be read as a statement by one who oversaw Islamabad. Especially when another gem declares, "The Pakistanis would happily lie to your face and continue to do what they were doing". But in a world where the nuclear meets the greedy, it isn't always clear where the lies come from, and when. Since both are quotes on record, it is worth relating the first as an observation about a US president, and the second about a system.

Deception, therefore, is about how such presidents and such a system conspired to produce what its authors declare as the nuclear crime of our lifetime. "So with the White House and 10 Downing Street unable to countenance an alternative, Musharraf's Pakistan remains at the epicentre of terror, a disingenuous regime with its hand on the nuclear tiller that has no hard and fast rules, no unambiguous goals or laws, and no line that cannot be bent or reshaped." Decade after decade, the story remains the same. The president who lied was Ronald Reagan.

As with all thrillers, *Deception* has a villain, with a supporting cast of gangsters. The villain is obviously the slippery Abdul Qadeer Khan, a Bhopal-born metallurgist metamorphosed into a scientist by a system that brooked no laws or lines. Powered by a psychology that sought to sweep a humble beginning under the carpet of history, the safari-suited short-cut artist punched at buttons until he struck gold. Zulfikar Ali Bhutto plucked him from dour Dutch suburbia and gave him a licence to set in motion his metamorphosis into someone who, three decades later, would tell a pleading

Musharraf, "I can help you, but I won't. Go and lick Bush's balls."

Between that supplication to Bhutto and the rebuff of Musharraf is a tale remarkable for its audacity, its scale of treachery, brazenness, and an astonishing absence of scruples. It is a tale of one man's rise and fall, but it is more than that. There are ample accounts of espionage, smuggling, murder, illicit materials and sex. It is an account of a State that encouraged the violation of any international agreement; undermined any relationship, bilateral or

Hussein was in the frame and Iraq was configured as 'the place to start'." Nuggets like this abound in the book.

But between the surreptitious beginnings to setting off global alarm bells is the cast of baddies. To use a colloquial phrase, there are many in the Turkish bath. It, of course, begins with the Dutch, West Germans participate, the British bite the bait, the Chinese open a liberal channel, Arabs and Persians sponsor and purchase. Set in Dubai, and you get a Sri Lankan with a Malaysian partner whose father



DICTATING TERMS: Khan (left) with President Musharraf

multilateral, in order to achieve its objective of possessing the fission device. But the acquisitiveness led to more—making and then marketing the bomb. Little wonder that a prescient American labelled Pakistan the Walmart of proliferation. "It was Pakistan that had offered to sell nuclear warheads, that had bred terrorism like other nations farmed rare breeds, that had brought the nuclear and terrorist worlds close together. Yet Saddam

became the prime minister. A Swiss businessman ran their factory. Throw in Italian ports and you have all the ingredients of a potboiler. And to cap the irony, there was indeed a Turk, but who died when tortured by his police. *Deception* even has an Israeli supplying oscilloscopes and spark gaps to one Humayun Khan, who runs a business firm called Pakland. There is also a Libyan called 'triple m'. A North Korean diplomat witnesses the tests in Chagai, and his wife gets killed days later by a hit team suspected to be ISI.